Trivet: a recipe box that remembers your household

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Trivet is a household recipe box, weekly planner and shopping list I designed and shipped on my own, directing an AI coding assistant as my engineering team. It closes a loop most recipe apps leave open: what we cook shapes what it suggests next.

The problem

Our dinners were scattered across printed meal-kit cards, saved links and a cooking subscription, and planning the week was a separate chore from shopping for it.

- **Recipes had no single home.** A stack of photographed cards, web pages and paper, none of it searchable together.
- **Planning started from a blank page.** Every week began with "what are we eating?" and the same few answers.
- **The shopping list was rebuilt by hand** from whatever got planned, then sent to whoever was going to the shop.

The recipe apps I tried put their effort into collecting recipes, especially from social feeds. Our problem wasn't collecting; it was the week: choosing, shopping and remembering what we'd already had.

My role

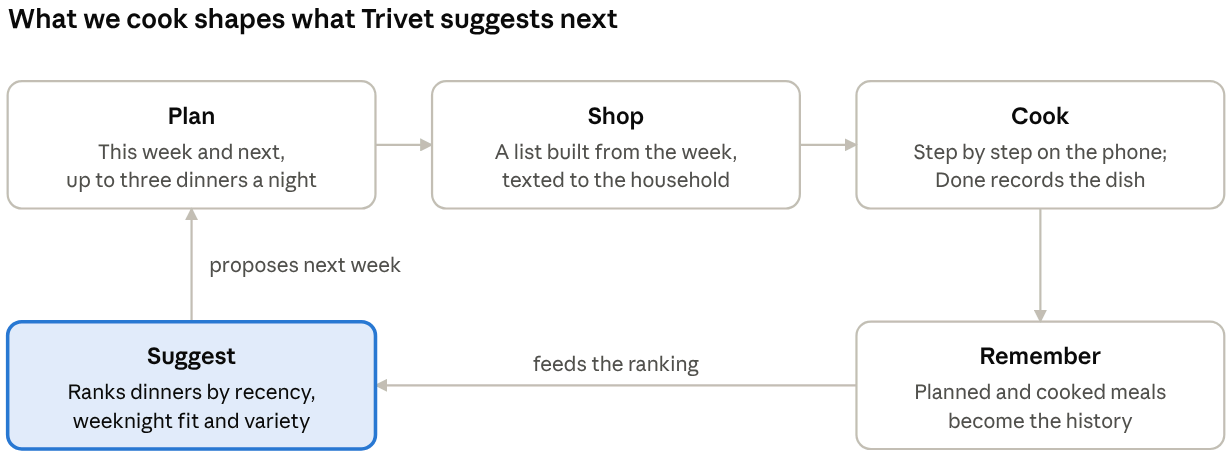
I was the product owner and designer; an AI coding assistant (Claude Code) wrote the code. I decided what to build, what to call it and what to cut, and I reviewed every change before it shipped.

I did	The AI did
Chose the problems worth solving, from our own use	Read the codebase and proposed how to build each piece
Named things and set the tone of every label	Wrote the code, tests and database changes

I did	The AI did
Made the calls when options conflicted	Ran a separate "design reviewer" pass on layouts and copy
Reviewed each change, then pushed and merged it	Checked every change in a real browser at phone width
Cut features that weren't earning their place	Reported dead ends plainly, with sources

A typical feature ran in an evening: I described the need, the assistant asked design for a ruling, built it, showed me screenshots, and I merged it the same day. Most of my work was judgment, not typing.

How it works



the Trivet loop · five steps

Most recipe apps stop at the recipe. Trivet keeps going: what we plan and cook becomes history, and that history decides what it suggests for next week.

Key decisions

The decisions that shaped Trivet were mostly about what to trust and what to leave out.

Decision	What I chose	Why
What powers suggestions	Our planning and cooking history, not star ratings	We rarely rate anything. Every week we plan records what we actually chose, so the signal was already there.
Testing the ranking	Ship it first inside the existing recipe picker	It only changed which dishes appeared first, so a wrong order was cheap to find before it decided anything.
Naming the week feature	"Suggest dinners," not "Fill the week"	"Fill" implied the app decides. "Suggest" says nothing goes on the plan until you press Add. "Dinners," not "meals," because that's all it fills.
Sorting recipes by course	A one-time pass I did by hand	Breakfasts were being offered for Tuesday dinner. Sorting our own library by hand fixed it better than any guesswork.
How far ahead to plan	This week and next, nothing else	That's how we really plan. Any other week now goes back to this one.
Counting off-plan cooking	Record a dish when Done is pressed in cook mode	I cook without planning sometimes. Opening a recipe isn't proof; finishing it is.
Phone screens	Treat height as the scarcest space	Most use is on a phone at the counter. Every layout was checked at phone width before it shipped.

What I cut

Killing things was as much of the work as building them. Each cut below removed something that looked useful but wasn't earning its place.

- **Grocery ordering.** I explored Instacart, Amazon Fresh, Whole Foods, Samsung Food and Stop & Shop. Instacart's developer program is closed with no waitlist, and none of the others offer an ordering API. The Amazon buttons only opened one search per ingredient, and nobody fills a week's basket that way, so I removed them. Texting the list to the household stayed, because it works.
- **Social-feed import.** Instagram and TikTok are where many people find recipes now, and capturing from them is the headline feature of several recipe apps. That's why I didn't lead with it: capture is crowded and largely solved, the platforms don't hand over recipe text cleanly, and doing it well means building and maintaining a native app. I spent the effort on what happens after a recipe is saved, which few apps do. I tried the cheap routes for TikTok anyway, then rolled them back when each hit the platform; screenshots are the way in (see Web or app).
- **A view of past weeks.** The ranking already brings back a dish we haven't had in a while, at the moment we're choosing. A browsable archive would have answered idle curiosity, not a decision.
- **Required phone numbers.** I made a phone number required at sign-up, then reversed it: it only buys one feature, and it was a barrier for everyone who didn't want texts.

The pattern: if a feature didn't change how a household plans, shops or cooks each week, it didn't stay.

Outcome

Trivet is live on the web and is how our household plans, shops and cooks every week.

- **Library:** recipes imported from web pages, PDFs, photos of cards and screenshots, several at once for a recipe that runs across screens, plus 90 starter recipes, each sorted by course.
- **Planner:** this week and next, up to three dinners and a side per evening, with Suggest Dinners proposing a week from our own history.
- **Shopping:** a list built from the week that skips pantry staples, printable, and texted to the household.
- **Cooking:** a step-by-step cook mode for the phone, servings scaling, and a record of every dish made: "Made twice, last on 30 October."
- **Household:** shared by invitation, with recipes that can be shared between households.

In real use: I planned and cooked appetizers for a dinner party from it, and going back to a recipe to see when we last made it turned out to be one of my favourite details. A pearl couscous salad from TikTok came in as screenshots of its long caption, read as one recipe. Behind it sit over 900 automated tests, so changes ship without breaking what works.

Web or app

Trivet runs on the web, and a thin iPhone app is now in a family beta. This is how I decided how far to go native.

The question came up through recipe capture. Many people now find recipes on Instagram and TikTok, and apps like ReciMe let you share a post straight in, with an AI agent that listens to the video. I tried three cheap routes to the same result on the web, and each one ran into the platform:

1. Reading a TikTok link's caption through TikTok's embed service. TikTok's documentation says the caption is there; in practice it no longer is.
2. Following the recipe link a creator puts in the caption. That needs the caption first.
3. Reading the preview text TikTok publishes for iMessage and Slack. TikTok doesn't give it to a server.

Instagram is closed the same way. So capture from both is a screenshot of the caption, uploaded as one photo or several for a long one, which Trivet reads as a single recipe. I rolled the TikTok link feature back rather than leave a promise in the app that doesn't hold.

What would close the gap, a share button inside those apps or an agent that watches the video, pulls toward a native app or toward scraping, which both platforms forbid.

	Web (today)	Native app
Capture	Recipe-page links, screenshots, an iPhone Shortcut	A share button inside Instagram and TikTok; video handling
Cost	Ships the moment I push a change	App Store review, a second build, ongoing upkeep
Reach	Any browser, nothing to install	An install, but a home-screen icon

What would make me switch: other households asking for it, or screenshots proving too clumsy for the recipes we actually save.

In progress: a family beta. I took the cheapest route to a home-screen icon: a thin iPhone app that wraps the existing site, not a rebuild. A React Native version meant rewriting every screen, roughly two to three months, for little the web didn't already do. The shell took days. Sign-in persists, the camera reads recipe cards, and links to other sites open in Safari. Apple approved it for TestFlight in November, and it's out to my family on their own phones.

The beta decides what, if anything, needs to be native. The first candidate is the shopping list in a shop with no signal, which I've designed but not built.

What I learned

With AI doing the building, the scarce skill is judgment: knowing what's worth building, and saying no to the rest.

- **Use beats research.** Every good feature started with something I noticed while cooking. The ranking, Suggest Dinners and the cooked-meal history all came from friction in our own week.
- **Test the cheap version first.** Putting the ranking inside the existing picker showed whether the order felt right before it was trusted to plan a whole week.
- **Words are product decisions.** "Suggest" versus "fill" changed what people would expect to happen when they pressed it.
- **Dead ends are findings.** Learning that grocery ordering was closed everywhere saved me from building the wrong thing.

What's next: let the beta decide what goes native.

- **Offline shopping list.** A saved copy of the list that opens in a shop with no signal. Items can be crossed off on the phone, and they reach the household's list only when someone chooses to send them, back in range.
- **A share sheet.** Share a recipe website or a photo of a card into Trivet from any app. TikTok maybe, if its share includes the caption; Instagram no.